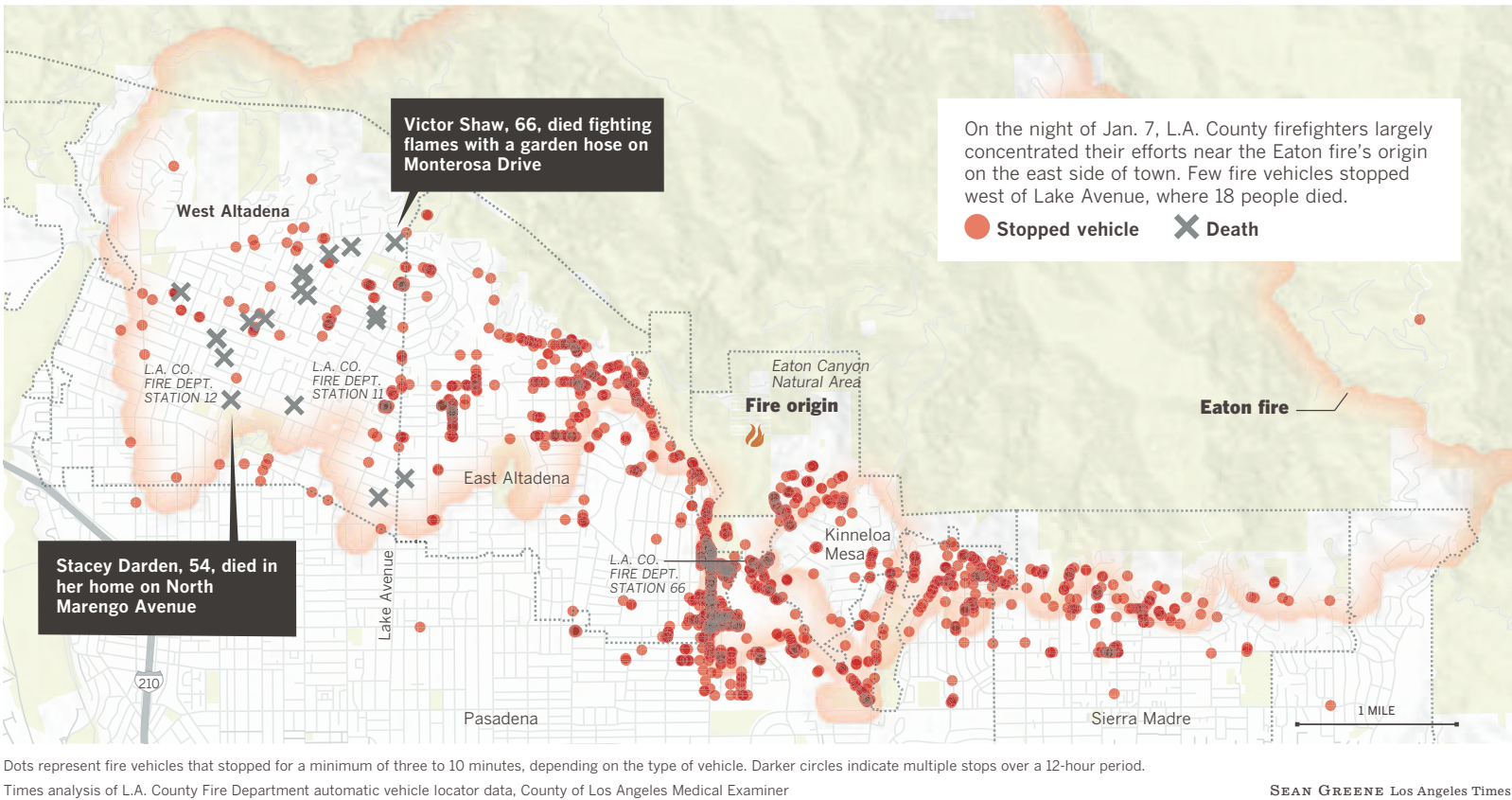




A TIMES INVESTIGATION

As west Altadena burned, county fire trucks stayed elsewhere

West Altadena was burning, and no one was there to save it.

More than 40 Los Angeles County fire trucks surrounded the Palisades fire, where an inferno was entering its 17th hour. An additional 64 fire trucks fanned out across east Altadena and neighboring areas, battling a blaze that had sparked in Eaton Canyon nine hours earlier.

But in west Altadena — where thousands of structures would burn and all but one of the 19 deaths from the Eaton fire would occur — there was just one county fire truck as the flames spread at 3:08 a.m. on Jan. 8, according to automatic vehicle locator data obtained by The Times.

“We were abandoned,” said Sofia Vidal, 57, one of more than a dozen residents interviewed by The Times who said they stayed dousing flames through the night with no firefighters in sight. “I never heard a siren.”

Six months after the fire, the anger is palpable, with residents of the racially diverse unincor-

Vehicle locator data show most didn’t come for hours. Angry residents wonder: Why?

By Rebecca Ellis and Sean Greene

porated area, long a refuge for Black families, convinced that they suffered from weaker fire protection than whiter, wealthier areas near the Palisades fire.

The sense of neglect is so intense that nearly 1 in 5 residents believes the county Fire Department let the town burn on purpose, according to an Altadena-based public interest research firm that interviewed more than 1,200 residents.

“Am I grateful for firemen? Not at all,” said Vidal, who fled her home with her husband at 5:45 a.m. after burning squirrels began to fall from their palm tree. “Did they fail me miserably? Absolutely.”

The L.A. County Fire Department’s top brass has described the destruction in west Altadena as almost inevitable. The wind was too intense. The flames were too violent. The whole night, unprecedented.

But the vehicle locator data, which show that most county fire trucks didn’t shift into west Altadena until long after [See Fire trucks, A4]

BONTA SEEKS TO CONTROL JUVENILE HALLS

California’s attorney general moves to take over the troubled L.A. County facilities.

By JAMES QUEALLY AND REBECCA ELLIS

California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta asked a judge Wednesday to place a court-appointed official in control of L.A. County’s juvenile halls, after years of violence, riots, drug overdoses, allegations of abuse and the death of a teenager.

“We must act” to protect youths, Bonta said at a news conference Wednesday morning. “Receivership is the only path forward that ensures their rights, their safety and their futures are no longer subject to institutional failure.”

Bonta said receivership means a court-appointed official would take over “management and operations of the juvenile halls” from the L.A. County Probation Department, including setting budgets and hiring and firing staff.

Bonta said he had given the county more than four years to fix the problems rampant in the halls. He called the county’s failure “repeated, constant and chronic.”

In a court filing made public Wednesday, Bonta said that L.A. County’s repeated failure to adhere to a 2021 settlement has led ju-

[See Juvenile, A14]

Plan for AI aims to cut red tape

By QUEENIE WONG

The Trump administration on Wednesday laid out a plan that aims to make it easier for companies to quickly develop and deploy artificial intelligence technology.

The initiative shows how Silicon Valley tech executives who backed Trump during the election are shaping federal policy that will affect their businesses as they compete globally to dominate the AI race.

“Artificial intelligence is a revolutionary technology with the potential to transform the global economy and alter the balance of power in the world,” David Sacks, the White House’s AI and crypto advisor, said in a statement. “To remain the leading economic and military power, the United States must win the AI race.”

Sacks is a co-founder and partner at Craft Ventures, a venture capital firm in San Francisco.

[See AI, A11]

AI ‘action plan’ being undermined

Experts say Trump team is sidestepping safety precautions and ignoring effects of cuts. **NATION, A6**



DELIVERY robots are set to roll Wednesday at Kreation Kafe in Santa Monica.

More delivery bots on menu

Coco Robotics will add hundreds to L.A.-area fleet

By PIPER HEATH AND CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

The robot invasion is coming to your neighborhood.

Coco Robotics, a startup born on the UCLA campus, is about to carpet-bomb the city with hundreds of additional adorable delivery bots recently enhanced with some of the same artificial intelligence that powers ChatGPT.

The company has been testing bots around the city for years, and it is at last confident enough in its technology that it plans to grow tenfold in the coming year, adding 9,000 bots to its current fleet of about 1,000 across the

country.

Residents of Silver Lake — one of the neighborhoods most recently occupied by delivery bots from Coco Robotics and others — give the rolling bots mixed reviews.

In the spring, Coco Robotics deployed about 10 food delivery robots to serve the neighborhood’s restaurants and residents. The pink, rounded machines represent the latest expansion for a company that started as a dorm-room project at UCLA in 2020 and now operates hundreds of robots from Santa Monica to downtown.

Silver Lake residents and retailers say their new neighbors are amusing and sometimes annoying.

On one of Silver Lake’s

many hillside streets, a robot delivering a burger from the Window restaurant took an unexpected route. Instead of following the most direct path, it turned up a steep hill and tried to climb some stairs before getting stuck. The machine sat motionless while somewhere a customer waited for lunch that would never arrive.

“The robot would’ve just stayed there forever if I did not cancel,” a former Silver Lake resident said in an interview on Reddit describing how a five-minute delivery turned into a comedy of errors. “I went without lunch.”

Coco Robotics chooses neighborhoods based on density, prioritizing areas [See Robots, A11]

Setbacks in L.A. for Trump appointee

President’s federal prosecutor struggles to secure indictments in Southland protests.

By JAMES QUEALLY AND BRITNY MEJIA

To bystanders at the federal courthouse in downtown Los Angeles, it sounded as though U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli would not take no for an answer.

A prosecutor had the irate Trump administration appointee on speaker phone outside the grand jury room, and his screaming was audible, according to three law enforcement officials aware of the encounter who spoke on condition of anonymity for fear of reprisals.

The grand jury had just refused to indict someone accused of attacking federal law enforcement officers during protests against the recent immigration raids throughout Southern California, two of the federal officials said.

It was an exceedingly rare outcome after a type of hearing that routinely leads to federal charges being filed.

On the overheard call, according to the three officials, Essayli, 39, told a subordinate to disregard the federal government’s “Justice Manual,” which directs prosecutors to bring only cases they can win at trial. Essayli barked that prosecutors should press on and secure indictments as directed by U.S. Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi, [See Essayli, A14]

‘A rapid collapse’ in trans care for kids

Closure of clinic at Children’s Hospital L.A. is part of national shift under Trump.

By SONJA SHARP

When Children’s Hospital Los Angeles first told thousands of patients it was shuttering its pediatric gender clinic last month, Jesse Thorn was distraught but confident he could quickly find a new local care team for his kids.

But by the time the Center for Transyouth Health and Development officially closed its doors on Tuesday, the father of three was making plans to flee the country.

“They’re targeting whoever they can,” Thorn said.

“[I’m afraid] the police will show up at my door because I took my child to see their doctor.”

Until this week, Children’s was among the largest and oldest pediatric gender clinics in the United States — and one of the few providing puberty blockers, hormones and surgical procedures for trans youth on public insurance.

The closure of the renowned program signals a wider unraveling in the availability of care across the country, experts said. That includes in former havens such as California, New York and Illinois, where state laws protecting trans-specific healthcare are crumbling under mounting legal pressure and bureaucratic arm-twisting by the Trump administration. [See Trans care, A5]

FDA experts under scrutiny

A panel discussion on antidepressants during pregnancy involved misinformation, doctors say. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

A tech mogul’s housing mission

Entrepreneur says that affordable development can be profitable. He created an investment fund. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Trump sets 15% tariff on Japan

Administration says the revenues will reduce budget deficit and that more factories will relocate to U.S. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Some sunshine. L.A. Basin: 83/62. **B6**

